

Understanding the Role of Brand Salience in Brand Choice Decisions in the Charity Sector

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**Liem Viet Ngo¹, Gary Gregory¹, Ryan Miller² and Lu Lu¹**

Abstract

Despite the importance of branding in customer acquisition, little is known about the extent to which brand salience influences brand choice intention of new customers. Drawing upon associative network memory theory, we propose that brand salience is composed of brand prominence and brand distinctiveness, which are linked to brand choice intention of new customers. Our theoretical contention was empirically examined in the context of monetary donation to international aid-related charities by new donors. A mixed-method approach was utilized with semi-structured interviews with practitioners and donors, and two cross-sectional surveys. The study offers a holistic view for understanding brand salience and, as such, advances recent work focusing on the breadth and depth of brand associations in the customer's mind.

Keywords

brand salience, prominence, distinctiveness, brand choice, charity, donor acquisition

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Introduction

Brand salience is gaining prominence as both a valid and effective form of distinction between competing brands across a range of categories within the corporate sector (Ehrenberg et al., 1997; Romaniuk, 2013, 2018; Romaniuk & Nenycz-Thiel, 2014; Sharp & Dawes, 2001). Relative brand salience, “the brand’s propensity to be noticed or come to mind in buying situations” (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2004, p. 327) is a reflection of how well known a brand is in relation to others, representing its prominence and distinctiveness in the mind of the consumer in question (Romaniuk et al., 2007; Sharp, 2010). Compared with other measures which were frequently used in past research, brand salience is a better proxy to measure brand values and predict consumer behaviors in social marketing or non-profit marketing because it can avoid the threat of social desirability which usually can cause the results to be spurious, especially in social marketing studies (Hong et al., 2008).

Despite the increasing attention being paid to brand salience initiating from Romaniuk and Sharp’s (2004) guidelines as to how a measure of brand salience might be constructed, there is a paucity of published scales. Indeed, most studies measure brand salience by counting the frequency or order of unaided or aided recall of brand name (e.g., Hong et al., 2008; Johnstone & Dodd, 2000). We find these methods overlook the position or space in consumers’ minds where the brand occupies (e.g., Romaniuk & Sharp, 2003; Viece & Shaw, 2010). In a recent study, Romaniuk and Nenycz-Thiel (2014) measured the strength of color brand-name links by adopting and comparing four measurement approaches. In the current study, we advance the extant literature in a unique way. Our theoretical premise is based on the influence of memory in the choice decision, which is frequently overlooked in the existing research on acquiring new customers, who may rely more heavily on memory-based heuristics

for choice due to a lack of category knowledge and the ability to easily compare competing brands. We propose a robust measure of brand salience, which represents a memory-related mechanism as an antecedent of brand choice.

We structure the article as follows. First, we detail a conceptualization of brand salience, as well as measurement guidelines following an exploratory analysis of existing literature. Next, we present the results of a qualitative study conducted to provide an initial test of a relationship between brand salience and brand choice intention and to develop a representative range of items for the measures within the context of study. We then present the results of two Australian surveys conducted among potential donors to charity to purify and test the measures and ultimately, to test the relationship between brand salience and brand choice intention. Finally, we discuss the research implications, study limitations, and propose areas of future research.

Conceptual Background and Exploratory Research

Brand salience

The concept of brand salience is grounded in associative network memory theory (Anderson, 1983; Anderson & Bower, 1980; Collins

¹The University of Adelaide, Australia

²Anglicare Sydney, Australia

Corresponding author:

Liem Viet Ngo, School of Marketing, UNSW Sydney, Kensington Campus, Sydney, NSW 2052, Australia.

Email: liem.ngo@unsw.edu.au

& Loftus, 1975; Pham & Johar, 1997), which describes knowledge as existing in memory as a network of linked nodes. Links between a brand and associations are created and reinforced as consumers are exposed to the brand in a specific context over time (Keller, 1993), increasing its relative prominence. The relative salience of a brand reflects the accessibility or prominence of this brand in memory (Hoeffler & Keller, 2003; Keller, 2008; Romaniuk & Sharp, 2003, 2004). Put simply, this is the likelihood a specific brand being thought of or noticed in relation to others in a certain buying situation (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2004). The more salient a brand, the greater its propensity to be recalled and the greater its likelihood to be considered for purchase (Vieceli & Shaw, 2010). This is influenced by the quantity and quality of links between the brand and associations in memory (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2003, 2004) and how distinctively the brand's core identity stands out from others (Romaniuk et al., 2007). For a summary of existing studies investigating elements of brand salience, see Table 1.

Based on an extensive review of past literature, two dimensions of brand salience are evident, namely prominence and distinctiveness. Inherent to prominence is an element of order, reflected in greater importance being attributed to specific brands being thought about over others in a particular situation, rather than how they are perceived (Miller & Berry, 1998). Prominence operates in a manner similar to conceptual fluency (A. Lee & Labroo, 2004), where the ease with which brands come to mind and are processed result in an increase in positive affect and hence, the likelihood of choice. Distinctiveness refers to the extent to which a brand stands out visually or is distinguished from its competitors due to its distinctive qualities such as colors, logos, and symbols (Romaniuk et al., 2007; Van der Lans et al., 2008). This is vital for a brand to be noticed in buying situations, as well as increase the chance that brands are correctly linked to advertising or communications, thereby creating or strengthening associations in memory (Sharp, 2010). Distinctiveness may operate in a manner similar to A. Lee and Labroo's (2004) conceptualization of perceptual fluency, where the ease with which a stimulus is identified on subsequent encounters through the processing of its physical features can result in positive affect and influence choice. Taken together, prominence and distinctiveness illustrate how relative brand salience can be used as a heuristic for choice, tapping into well-documented effects such as mere exposure (Zajonc, 1968), availability (Kahneman et al., 1982), and processing fluency (A. Lee & Labroo, 2004). New buyers are particularly prone to use simplifying heuristics for choice, as they may lack expertise in product comparison and hence choose to quickly reduce or discard options to arrive at a decision (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987; Lynch & Srull, 1982; Payne et al., 1988).

Given its associative network grounding, the brand salience concept incorporates a number of related constructs within it, including brand image/brand associations, brand knowledge, and brand awareness. Brand image is a function of the associations in memory in relation to that brand (Keller, 2008). Vieceli and Shaw (2010) argue that for a brand to be salient, customers must have a richness of information associated with each brand in their consideration set. In their empirical setting of fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG), they found brand image, as measured by the quantity, the valence, and the uniqueness of brand associations, is subsumed with brand knowledge. Brand knowledge is compiled through the familiarity and expertise resulting from previous brand-related experiences and associations (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987; Ehrenberg et al., 2002). Brand salience is also used interchangeably with the concept of brand awareness, though salience is considered to be a more comprehensive measure. Brand awareness only considers the link between a product category

and the brand (Sharp, 2010), while brand salience recognizes that there are more associations than just the product category that can cause customers to think of brands to buy (Nedungadi, 1990).

Existing approaches to measuring brand salience

Although the concept of brand salience has been discussed in the literature, the operationalization of this construct and the way to measure it, to the best of our knowledge, is still scarce. The most common way to measure brand salience has been via a simple recall test, that is, consumers are asked to list all brands in a product category (Alba & Chattopadhyay, 1986). For example, Johnstone and Dodd (2000) measured the salience of brands placed in a British film by counting the order of each brand. Similarly, Hong et al. (2008) measured the brand salience of placed products by comparing the differences of order before exposure and after exposure of a movie. Vieceli and Shaw (2010) criticized this method claiming it failed to account for customers' views of a product and the space and position that a product occupies in a customer's mind. They further argued that the effects of brand image on brand salience should be accounted and, in their empirical study, measured brand salience by subsuming brand image measures into the overall brand salience model. Romaniuk and Sharp (2003) followed a different approach by measuring the frequency of brand name recall or recognition, both aided and unaided, across a range of image attributes that consist of both descriptive and evaluative features in two tested markets: telecommunications and financial services. Arguably, compared to previous methods using top-of-mind awareness, this method may be a better reflection of the position that a brand occupies in a customer's mind (i.e., brand prominence). Later, Romaniuk and Sharp (2004) propose guidelines as to how a measure of brand salience might be constructed, to reflect the quantity and quality of associations with the brand in memory. It should contain a range of attributes or cues whereby brands could be thought of, such as consumption situations, benefits and functional qualities, and be relevant to all the brands in the category (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2003, 2004). The situational nature of the measure is clearly evident, requiring attributes to be devised and tested to match the context of the category. A further recommendation is that the range of attributes be measured simultaneously across a range of competitors, with regard to whether they cause a brand to be thought of or not, rather than on an evaluative basis (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2004).

While the scale development process described appears to measure prominence in memory (e.g., the propensity of the brand to come to mind), it seems deficient in terms of measuring the distinctiveness of the brand (e.g., the propensity of the brand to be noticed). The uniqueness of distinctive brand assets such as colors, logos, taglines, and symbols (Romaniuk et al., 2007) is an important aspect to capture in a representative measure, given the role played in assisting brands to be recognized (Sharp, 2010; Warlop et al., 2005). Although technically falling within the broader category of brand attributes, measurement of the unique linkages of assets with brands (Romaniuk et al., 2007) calls for a separate measure to be devised.

Research Methodology

Empirical setting

We selected the charity sector as the empirical setting. In nearly 50 years since the call first went out for the concept of marketing to be broadened to include charitable causes (Kotler & Levy, 1969), the nature and scope of the charity sector has evolved significantly. Worldwide charitable giving is expected to grow by \$233 billion by

Table 1. Review of Research on Brand Salience.

Authors (year)	Key findings	Definition of brand salience	Method to measure "Brand salience"
Johnstone & Dodd (2000)	Placements in cinema increase brand salience, especially among individuals who like (or attend to) the film and who are high self-monitors	The prominence or level of activation of the brand in memory	The first recalled brand
Romaniuk & Sharp (2003)	There will be a positive relationship between the number of image attributes the brand is associated with and loyalty to that brand	The probability of brand retrieval in consumers' mind, reflected in the number of attributes that could become brand retrieval cues	A calculation of the number of times the brand was mentioned across all the attributes presented to the respondent.
Romaniuk & Sharp (2004)	Brand salience is reflected in the quantity (how many) and the quality (how fresh and relevant) of the network of brand information in memory, or the brand's "share of mind." The research suggests three key factors as a measure of brand salience	Buyer's ease of recalling the brand and retrieval from memory	1. Contain a representative range of attributes/cues used to 'think of' brands; 2. Measure relative to competitors rather than for a single brand independently; 3. Focus on whether the brand is thought of rather than seeking to determine how favorably the brand is judged.
Romaniuk et al. (2004)	The measure of brand awareness and advertising awareness is a result of two factors: the brand salience in the consumer's mind, which increases its probability of being named, and the difficulty of the measure, which decreases the probability.	Propensity of the brand to come to mind in purchase situations	Top of mind, spontaneous and aided brand awareness
Hong et al. (2008)	Compared with non-demonstrative, positive-context product placement, demonstrative, negative-context product placement is more likely to foster brand salience	Unaided recall of the brand	Using pre-exposure questionnaires: listing five brand names for each of the product category
Remaud & Lockshin (2009)	The brand used by the wine region should be thought of as often as possible during a wine consumer's buying situation. The greater the salience of the brand, the greater the probability the brand will be thought of and the greater the chance for the brand to be purchased.	The probability that a brand will be recalled early in a consumer's consideration set, under a variety of situations and via a variety of stimuli, to the exclusion of competing brands	The propensity of the product to be noticed or thought of in buying situations
Vieceli & Shaw (2010)	For fast-moving consumer goods, there is a relationship between brand salience and purchase likelihood	The probability that a brand will be recalled early in a consumer's consideration set, under a variety of situations and via a variety of stimuli, to the exclusion of competing brands	A 22-item measure of retrieval of information, the structure of product knowledge, brand associations and brand image
Trembath et al. (2011)	The intention to visit a city for a holiday will be positively associated with the brand salience of that destination, even after considering previous visitation. While brand salience is often viewed as a "low involvement", this research investigates the relevance of brand salience in tourism and travel, which is considered a high involvement category.	The capacity of the brand itself to be retrieved	Using the method recommended by Romaniuk & Sharp (2004), that is the number of times each city (among 7 cities in Australia) was evoked in response to the set of salience cues
Boisvert (2012)	Contextual salience of the parent brand directly affects reciprocal transfer of image associations of a new vertical line extension but is not related to performance associations	Consumers' ability to retrieve the essence of the brand	Two levels of parent brand salience: high (participants assess the parent brand by rating it on 23 criteria just before assessing the new extension) vs. low (no task). The goal was for subjects to retrieve the essence of the parent brand and make it highly salient in each participant's top-of-mind memory during assessment of the extension. This method is using cognitive (Miller & Berry 1998) rather than visual support

(Continued)

Table I. (Continued)

Authors (year)	Key findings	Definition of brand salience	Method to measure "Brand salience"
Romaniuk (2013)	The NBD–Dirichlet model might be able to able to obtain predictions for a brand's mental market share and measure brand salience	A brand's mental market share	Associative penetration: the proportion of consumers with the brand node sufficiently salient in memory for retrieval for at least one cue. Association rate: measure of the size of the associative network, and is a representation of the number of attributes linking to the brand Share of Mind: the relative competitiveness of the brand's associative network in consumer memory, of those with some propensity to think of the brand
Cutright et al. (2014)	When brands are a highly salient tool for self-expression, individuals are less likely to report and demonstrate strong religious commitment	Whether the brand is present when consumers make product choices	Choice procedure was used to manipulate brand salience. In the high-brand salience condition, participants chose between two branded products, in four different sets. In the low-brand salience condition, participants chose between the same pairs of products except the brand names were removed
Romaniuk & Nenycz-Thiel (2014)	The association between a brand and a color is stronger under the Brand Cued condition than the Element Cued condition. Cue direction and the difficulty of the retrieval task interact to influence the nature of the responses obtained.	Network of distinctive elements that create a network of cues, such as audio memory, colors, shapes, or faces.	How easy the link between the element and the brand name can be retrievable from consumers' long-term memory
Pike & Bianchi (2016)	Destination brand salience is significantly and positively related to destination brand loyalty. In addition, destination brand salience is higher and has a stronger effect on destination brand loyalty for short-haul travelers than long-haul travelers, mainly due to geographic proximity.	The strength of awareness of the destination in the mind of an individual when a given travel situation is considered	Five items derived from Boo et al. (2009) and Konecnik and Gartner (2007)
Jahn et al. (2018)	Brand salience boosts the influence of retail experience on brand experience	The cognitive and affective bond that connects the brand with the self and makes the brand stand out from its competitors	Perceived (1) ease and (2) frequency with which brand-related thoughts and feelings are recalled (adopted from Park et al., 2010)

2030 (Charities Aid Foundation, 2012). In 2017 alone, Americans gave more than \$410 billion to 1.6 million registered non-profits (GivingUSA, 2018), a number that had escalated by 25% since 2011 (Blackwood et al., 2012). The sector in Australia is similarly dynamic, with charity income increasing from \$110 billion in 2014 to \$121 billion in 2016 (Powell et al., 2017). Despite the rapid growth evident in the sector, marketing's contribution to the realm of fundraising has only been recognized relatively recently and limited in two aspects. First, the extant literature has mainly focused on the means whereby specific charities might retain or increase the loyalty of existing givers. Research here primarily focuses on facets of donor loyalty and commitment (Sargeant & Lee, 2004), donor retention (Sargeant & Hudson, 2008), donor relationship marketing (Bennett & Barkensjo, 2005; Weir & Hibbert, 2000), and donor lifetime value (Bennett, 2006). Limited attention, however, has been paid to the acquisition of new donors for whom the choice between charities is central. Second, acquisition of new customers is of great importance to firms across profit- and non-profit sectors (Hui & Au, 2001, cf. Voss & Voss, 2008). This is particularly imperative for the charity sector, where the limited research devoted to charity choice is typically with regard to a belief in values-based brand personality as a

source of differentiation to facilitate selection (Aaker et al., 2010; De Chernatony & Riley, 1998; Venable et al., 2005; Voeth & Herbst, 2008), charities' brand orientation (Kylander & Stone, 2012; Z. Lee, 2013; Stride & Lee, 2007), and marketing orientation (Modi & Mishra, 2010). Little research has focused on the role of brand salience in new customer acquisition.

Given that brand salience may play a significant role in charity choice, there is scope to develop measures, so the construct may be included in comprehensive future models of charity choice or new donor acquisition. In the current study, we adopted a mixed-method approach to develop these measures, commencing with semi-structured interviews with marketing, media, and research managers from two large international aid and relief organizations. These were conducted to further validate the perceived influence of brand salience on choice and compile a list of attributes and distinctive assets for the construct measures. We selected international aid and relief as a contextual base due to the relatively high levels of awareness of related charity brands, regular exposure of the public to context-related needs and high levels of public interest in poverty and international assistance (Micklewright & Schnepf, 2009). The expert interviews were supplemented with interviews with first-time donors to these charities. Although conducted to

Table 2. Qualitative Study Sample—“Once-Off” Donor Interviews.

	Name ^a	Participant background	Gender	Family circumstance	Organization supported
1.	Kate	Lawyer	Female	Living with partner, no children	Oxfam
2.	Kelly	Marketer	Female	Engaged, no children	Oxfam
3.	Sarah	Stay-at-home mom, PhD graduate	Female	Married, one young child	Oxfam
4.	Rachel	Psychologist	Female	Married, two young children	Oxfam
5.	Patricia	Online marketer	Female	Living with partner, no children	Oxfam
6.	John	IT professional, refugee	Male	Married, two young children at home	World Vision
7.	Natalie	Travel consultant	Female	Married, no children	World Vision
8.	Bronwyn	Campaign manager	Female	Single, no children	World Vision
9.	Andrew	Administrator	Male	Married, two adult children at home	World Vision
10.	Matt	Tour guide	Male	Single, no children	World Vision

IT: information technology.

^aName of respondent is fictitious to protect identity.

generate similar attribute data as the prior interviews and provide an initial test of distinctive brand assets, there is particular value in understanding the choice process from the perspective of the first-time donor. Results from the qualitative research component were used as a basis for two cross-sectional surveys for the purposes of scale purification. Data from the first survey enabled us to conduct an analysis of the prevalence of brand salience attributes, resulting in some scale revision. The second survey facilitated the testing of the construct for indicator significance and multicollinearity.

Study I—Qualitative Study

Sampling procedure and sample characteristics

We conducted semi-structured, in-depth expert interviews with two different sets of respondents. The first set of respondents included nine experts in marketing, media, and research from World Vision Australia (4) and Oxfam Australia (5). The second set of respondents included 10 “once-off” donors from each World Vision and Oxfam who had donated in response to the Haiti earthquake of 2010 and who have not donated to either organization since. Our goal in collecting data from these two samples was to obtain both a professional and layperson’s perspective on key brand attributes involved in charity choice and to corroborate these brand elements across samples to increase validity of our brand salience measures. Table 2 provides key characteristics of the sample of “once-off” donors. Prospective participants were screened to ensure that they were not regular givers to charities involved with the provision of international aid and relief and that they had only given once to the organizations in question. All were residents of Sydney, Australia, but resided in locations across the breadth of the city. A small payment was offered for participation.

Interview guide

For both the expert and once-off donor interviews, guides comprising predominantly open-ended questions were prepared in advance using concept-related themes identified in the non-profit marketing literature. Such questions provide a framework for discussion where respondents are free to express their views in ways that best reflect their professional or personal experience. The answers provided can, in part, guide the conversation as the interviewer can vary the order of the questions and ask additional questions in response to them (Loi & Pearce, 2012). Experts first provided responses relating to their perceptions of the international aid category and its competitive nature, donor behavior, and organizational brand strategy. Thereafter, they assisted with the generation of attributes and distinctive assets

for the brand salience measure following explanation of the nature of the construct. In contrast, once-off donors were required to describe how they decided to donate to the cause in question and how they selected a charity brand. Given the situational nature of the brand salience measure, donors’ associations with natural disaster and the needs arising from them were captured to reflect the prominence aspect of the construct in the giving situation. These formed the basis for representative category attributes, given the responses reflected the typical images broadcast by the media or charities themselves and hence, the cues that would cause brands to be thought of. Following unprompted generation of brand assets that donors believed were distinctive to brands in the category, a prompted matching exercise of a range of these with brands was conducted to test the prevalence of the distinctive assets identified by the category experts. This exercise assisted with the development of the distinctiveness dimension of the brand salience measure.

Analysis and interpretation

All interviews lasted for between an hour and 90 minutes each. They were recorded, transcribed, and then subjected to a content analysis using QSR NVivo 9 software. Coding techniques follow those prescribed by Miles and Huberman (1994), with codes being assigned to segments of text to reduce “large mountains of raw data into small, manageable piles” (Neuman, 2006, p. 460). Categorized data were abstracted into concepts and integrated into existing theory, thereby developing a coherent framework that could facilitate accuracy in concept development and specification of the relationships between them (as per Spiggle, 1994). Opinions of experts and donors are captured separately, to demonstrate areas of congruence and difference.

Findings

In-depth interviews with once-off donors broadly confirmed the view of experts that little conscious thought was given to the choice decision but gave far greater insight into what influenced the decision. A quick decision regarding which charity to support appears to be the norm, with both brand salience and prevailing brand attitudes influencing the decision. In the case of a natural disaster or emergency, the resulting need is the motivation to give, not the charities. Brand salience is clearly critical though. Broad-based brand awareness causes a brand to be thought of or noticed in the giving situation, due to its prominence and distinctiveness in memory. The prominence of the brand in memory can even cause the brand to be selected automatically. Very little research or external search is conducted with regard to the charity choice decision, if any.

Prominence. In terms of prominence, experts spoke at length about the aspects of natural disasters that they believe arouse the public and cause them to take notice. Many considered the nature of disasters that were characterized by significant public fundraising in their aftermath. These attributes would cause individuals to consider donating and, by association, think of recipient brands. Among others, experts considered scale and broad impact of the disaster, immediacy and unforeseen nature of the event, high level of casualty, difficulty of the operation for rescue personnel, and the need for long-term rebuilding to be attributes that could cause various brands to come to mind.

Distinctiveness. In terms of noticing and correctly identifying a brand, experts proposed categories and examples of brand assets for a range of charities providing international aid and relief services. In general, logos, colors, campaigns, visual imagery, and representative ambassadors were considered to be areas where certain brands had distinctive assets, while taglines were rejected across the board. Colors and logos were most persuasive; however, a number of brands were identified as having distinctive assets in categories where other brands were deficient. The experts generated a range of examples by category and by brand.

When asked to think of distinctive brand assets for unprompted charities providing international aid and relief, once-off donors were easily able to identify a range of these for certain categories but not for others. In addition, donors were more easily able to generate examples for the brand they had once supported than for others in the category. Campaigns were also easily linked to a range of charities, as were colors and logos. However, logos often proved difficult to describe. Although a number of participants shared some quite vivid images that they thought distinctive to specific charities, these varied considerably from individual to individual.

Regarding images associated with charities, this asset category appears inherently subjective. For example, given the range of distinctive images associated with the Red Cross, including a Toyota Land Cruiser, tented camps, and doctors in white coats, it was difficult to determine a distinctive finite set of image assets for any particular charity outside of the distinctive red-colored cross logo. In terms of brand ambassadors, most cannot remember the celebrity endorsers of international aid and relief charities apart from a few exceptions such as Angelina Jolie for United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF). When given a prompted matching task and required to link charities with brand assets, donors were again able to link colors, logos, and campaigns with charity brands, but struggled with ambassadors and distinctive images. These two categories do not appear suitable for use in a relative measure of distinctiveness as a component of brand salience.

Measure construction

Drawing upon existing literature on brand salience and further evidence from the qualitative study, we propose that brand salience be modeled as a formative measure. Given that a significant number of top-level studies are characterized by indefinite measurement models caused by formative measurement models being treated as reflective (Jarvis et al., 2003), this contention is worthy of further discussion. In formative specifications, a higher-order construct is viewed as being caused by its dimensions, which do not need to be correlated (Ulaga & Eggert, 2006). Dimensions are not interchangeable, where the removal of an indicator could be considered as "omitting a part of the construct" (Bollen & Lennox, 1991, p. 308). This contrasts with reflective measurement models, where dimensions are considered interchangeable, strongly correlated and caused by higher-order constructs. The more prominent or distinctive a charity brand is in the mind of a potential donor, the more likely it is to be thought of or noticed in a specific donation situation. The dimensions clearly

cause the higher-order construct, not the reverse, while they do not necessarily need to correlate. For example, a charity brand may be highly salient in the mind of a potential donor due to its distinctive logo and hence be noticed yet may not be thought of as related to the representative attributes of a specific occasion. An example of such a situation is in relation to the Red Cross. Their logo is one of the most recognized and distinctive of any organization in the world, yet much of their aid-related work is rarely advertised which would hinder the formation of links between the brand and associations in memory.

Study 2—Quantitative Study

Brand salience measure development

Prior to quantitative analysis of the brand salience construct, the items generated from the literature and qualitative interviews were assessed for content and face validity. For content validity, the measure must represent "all the aspects of the conceptual definition of a construct," while face validity is evaluated in terms of whether the items make sense as construct measures in the judgment of other industry or scientific experts (Neuman, 2006, pp. 192–193). The item pool of 14 prominence-related attributes and a representative range of logos, colors, and activities to reflect distinctiveness were subjected to scrutiny by a panel of judges comprising four marketing and research managers from World Vision and Oxfam who did not participate in the expert interviews. To achieve face validity, each judge was provided with definitions of the construct and then required to appraise each item for appropriateness and clarity, using a measurement scale from one to five (Pritchard et al., 1999). To be included in a final item pool, a majority of the judges were required to score the item a three or higher on each criterion. Judges were also provided the opportunity to comment on the representativeness of the constructs for construct validity. Following the exclusion of items due to the lack of face validity and inclusion of a couple at the instruction of judges, 12 prominence-related attributes were retained. All distinctive properties were retained.

Survey instrument development

Scale purification was conducted by means of two online surveys. Given that the conceptualization of a formative indicator measurement model is statistically under identified when taken in isolation, the conceptualized brand salience measure can only be estimated within a larger model that includes consequences of the latent variable under investigation (Bollen & Lennox, 1991; Diamantopoulos & Winklhofer, 2001). Hence, the surveys were developed with the primary objective of informing a model of charity brand choice intention and thereby simultaneously providing a means whereby the scales measuring the brand salience construct could be purified and tested.

Scenario

We used a natural disaster scenario (Appendix 1), comprising a fictitious report of a recent Tsunami in Bali, as stimulus for survey respondents prior to answering questions relating to their intended charity choice and relative brand salience with regard to a range of brands. This scenario, developed in conjunction with leading international aid organizations to simulate the feeling and emotion of a natural disaster, had been prior tested for its ability to facilitate transportation, whereby individuals become immersed in the narrative and consider it as if real (Green, 2004). To test this scenario, 98 undergraduate and postgraduate students at a large Australian university took part in an online, lab-based experiment where four scenario variations were presented. The scenario that was ranked highest according to Green & Brock's transportation scale (2000) was used as stimulus for the surveys.

Scales

Each item comprising the brand salience construct is a relative proportional scale. To generate a score for prominence, we developed a free choice “pick any” prompted measure whereby respondents were asked to identify the brands they think of when considering each attribute, such as “when help is needed immediately.” Hence, each brand’s relative prominence score would be the number of attributes that cause the brand to be thought of, if any, as a percentage of the total number of attributes. Similarly, to generate a score for distinctiveness, respondents were asked to link the prompted brands with items, such as logos or colors from a range of distinctive assets within each category. A small number of decoy assets that did not match with any of the prompted brands were also included in each category. The difference between distinctiveness and prominence measure is that for distinctiveness measures the respondent must link the correct asset(s) with the brand in question for the association to count. Each brand’s relative distinctiveness score would be the number of brand assets correctly associated with that brand as a percentage of the total number of possible asset associations. Both of these measures tap into the quantity of links in memory, as they capture the number of associations as well as the quality of links, as they are measured relative to other brands. Free choice is preferred over forced choice scales or ranks, as these can confound unawareness or indifference. For example, if respondents are required to link brands to associations where they may be unfamiliar with the brands involved, means tend toward the midpoint in semantic differential scales (Hughes, 1969). Forced choice measures also have the potential for “pseudo beliefs” to be added to the data, resulting in over reporting (Barnard & Ehrenberg, 1990).

Four of the largest charity brands in the international aid and relief sector in Australia (Red Cross, World Vision, Oxfam, UNICEF) based on historic share of disaster donations (Australian Council for International Development, 2005), organizational turnover, and brand awareness were prompted to provide choice comparison. Despite all being relatively well-established brands in Australia, Red Cross and World Vision are significantly larger than Oxfam and UNICEF. Brands are prompted to reduce the risk of brands with smaller market shares being crowded out in memory by brands with high levels of awareness, with attributes or associations less likely to be elicited (Laurent et al., 1995; Romaniuk, 2006). In addition, non-brand users, such as first-time potential donors, are less likely to give associations when not prompted, while brand users tend to give the same for prompted or unprompted (Romaniuk, 2006). The use of a prompted measure in contrast to an unprompted one should not impact on validity. Linear relationships between aided and spontaneous awareness have been reported, illustrating that brands with low salience “score low on any awareness measure, and high salience brands score high” (Romaniuk et al., 2004, p. 77).

Respondents could only move forward through the survey and were not permitted to move backward or change responses once they had moved beyond the page in question. This was done to ensure that exposure to prompted salience and attitude-related information in latter sections of the survey did not influence choices made in earlier sections or “jog” the memories of respondents where associations or brand assets had not been spontaneously associated with brands.

Sampling procedure and sample characteristics

A leading market research provider administered the two surveys, utilizing their online panel. Great care was taken in the selection of the provider, given the concerns by a number of experts that responses given by web panelists may not be representative of the population under consideration due to displaying different traits to individuals who choose not to participate in this kind of research (Brüggen & Dholakia, 2010). The provider demonstrated evidence

of the panel being representative, given its 370,000 active members, that half of the panelists are recruited offline and that panelists are not over incentivized to prevent “professional respondents.” Data integrity is maintained through random selection of the sampling frame from quota groups, only unique respondents being included and no “top-up” panels used. A top-up is when an external panel is used because the existing panel offered by the research provider cannot meet the sample size or target group required for the project in question. Individuals are also rewarded with an incentive if they are screened out, to prevent respondents entering false information in the hope of qualifying to complete the survey. “Skimmers,” individuals who took significantly less time than the average respondent to complete the survey, as well as those identified to be answering questions with a discernible pattern (e.g., answering all 1–7 scale questions as a “7”) were excluded from the final results.

For both surveys, a sampling frame of potential donors to international aid and relief was selected to corresponded with the demographic profile of Australian givers to charity as per Lyons and Passey (2005) and the geographical spread of the population across Australia (Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2011). The selected respondents were screened to exclude pledge givers to international aid charities and those who contributed once or more per year, with the sample skewed slightly toward younger respondents given the higher relative propensity for these individuals to be first-time donors to international aid (Aeberhard, 2008). Respondents were required to be over the age of 18 and be Australian citizens.

Scale purification—Survey 1

A preliminary survey to further purify scales was conducted resulting in a final sample of 51 respondents based on the selection requirements. In total, 332 panelist responses were received from 1999 invitations, of which 82 dropped out, 76 were excess to quota requirements, and 123 were screened out as not meeting the necessary criteria for inclusion before a sample size of at least 50 for analysis purposes was reached (Hair et al., 2006). Attributes composing the measure for the prominence dimension of brand salience were reduced to 10 from 12, as the two attributes removed had markedly lower levels of association with the prompted brands than the others. When compared according to the number of total associations of the attributes with the prompted brands, the two excluded attributes demonstrated total responses greater than 1.5 standard deviations below the mean for the group and a relatively high number of respondents indicating that they associate none of the brands listed with the associations in question. All distinctive properties were retained. The final lists of prominence-related attributes and distinctive properties are included as Appendix 2 and Appendix 3.

Measurement model—Survey 2

The second survey, conducted with 402 respondents, matched the sampling qualification characteristics of the first, but reflected the changes to the number of brand salience attributes from the first survey. A total of 1,902 panelist responses were received from 11,346 invitations, of which 417 dropped out, 113 were excess to quota requirements, and 970 were screened out. A random sample of 300 was selected for further analysis rather than the full sample, as the full sample is to be used for future testing of a more comprehensive model of donor decision.

The partial least squares (PLS) approach to structural equation modeling (SEM) was chosen to holistically confirm the measurement model. This approach is becoming increasingly popular (Hair et al., 2011) due to its robustness and ability to model latent variables with both formative and reflective indicators (Hulland, 1999), where

Table 3. Table of Measures for UNICEF.

Construct	Item	Weight	Loading	SE	t-value
Brand salience (formative)					
	Prominence	0.85		0.06	13.43**
	Distinctiveness	0.45		0.10	4.38**
Brand choice intention (reflective)					
CR = 0.84	Likelihood of choice		0.89	0.02	43.49**
AVE = 0.72	Donation magnitude		0.80	0.04	21.83**

UNICEF: United Nations Children's Fund; SE: standard error; CR: composite reliability; AVE: average variance extracted.

**Significant at .01 level.

data distributions may be non-normal (Fornell & Bookstein, 1982) and with relatively small samples (Hair, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2011).

The responses received from participants informed the development of a model of brand choice intention, in order for the formative brand salience construct to be suitably estimated and tested. Within this model, brand salience is included as an independent variable with brand choice intention as the dependent variable.

Brand choice intention. Brand choice intention comprises two reflective items as shown in Appendix 4. The first item captures the likelihood of donation to each of the four specific brands using a 1–7 scale where 7 is *very likely*, while the second item is a proportional measure of the value of a donation allocated to each of the brands given a total value of \$200 that the respondent hypothetically plans to donate. Respondents were required to use the full \$200 across the four brands, where they could choose to give all the money to one organization or split it across up to three of the brands. We considered the use of two items as opposed to just a single item to provide a more comprehensive measure of the construct and also improve the estimation of the measurement model by decreasing the variation in parameter estimates in PLS (Reinartz et al., 2009). Meijer (2009) provides a precedent by considering both basic donor support and the amount of money donated to an organization as important criterion variables when considering the effect of donor attitudes toward the charity.

Table 3 presents pertinent information pertaining to the weights and loadings of the latent variable measures and the associated *t*-values for UNICEF, as well as other data of relevance for validity testing. Although any of the four organizations could have been chosen as the exemplar brand, UNICEF was selected due to its consistently high level of global prominence. In comparison, although internationally active and recognized, Oxfam and World Vision have inherent territorial strengths. As shown in Table 3, all items have significant path loadings or weights ($p < .01$). All reported results relate to the UNICEF charity brand but are extended through discussion to the other represented brands in the survey, especially where findings differ across brands. Although the focus remains the brand salience construct, values for the brand choice intention construct are briefly included for completeness. Significance of the indicator's weight is determined by means of bootstrapping (cf. Chin, 1998), while also useful for evaluation of the absolute importance of an indicator to the construct reflected in its loading (Hair, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2011). As is evident in Table 3, we find both indicators conceptualized to form the brand salience construct to have significant path weights and hence make a meaningful contribution to the construct index.

We also examined the formative indicators for redundancy, through assessment of the level of multicollinearity among them. Excess collinearity can cause the influence of individual indicators on the latent variable to become indistinct (Diamantopoulos & Winklhofer, 2001), thereby causing indicators to be non-significant

and face exclusion. The degree of multicollinearity in the indicators is determined by calculating a variance inflation factor (VIF), where scores for each indicator should be less than 5 (Hair et al., 2011). The VIF for both the indicators was 1.012, which is well below the threshold.

Given the support for the brand salience construct stemming from its theoretical conceptualization and now from the relevant statistical criteria, the quality of the formative measurement model is evident. However, when examining the constituent construct indicators in relation to the choice intention toward Oxfam, World Vision, and Red Cross, we find some variation in the contribution of the “distinctiveness” indicator. Where the “prominence” indicator demonstrates significance in terms of weight and loading across all brands, the results for “distinctiveness” vary, as is evident in Table 4. These findings are considered in the discussion section to follow.

As a reflective measurement model, brand choice intention for the four charity brands (i.e., UNICEF, Oxfam, World Vision, Red Cross) was assessed for both reliability and validity. Composite reliability scores of the four charity brands (i.e., from 0.74 to 0.84) and their scores of average variances extracted (i.e., from 0.58 to 0.72) were satisfactory.

Structural model

Table 4 displays the results for the relationship between the two latent variables across all four brands, ranked in descending order of annual turnover in Australia. Positive beta values range from .444 to .489 which, when bootstrapped, all demonstrate high *t*-values (9.733–11.061) and significance ($p < .01$). R^2 values for brand choice intention as the criterion variable vary from .197 for World Vision to .239 for Oxfam. These values are particularly notable given that the explained variance in the model is only due to brand salience. We find this to be compelling evidence of the explanatory ability of brand salience with regard to charity brand choice.

We also tested two alternative models: one with just prominence and another with just distinctiveness. In the first model, we found significant effects of prominence on brand choice intention across the four brands ($b = .372 \div .422$; $t = 8.075 \div 10.716$; $R^2 = .138 \div .185$). In the second model, we found significant effects of distinctiveness on brand choice intention across UNICEF ($b = .219$; $t = 4.708$; $R^2 = .048$), Oxfam ($b = .192$; $t = 4.284$; $R^2 = .037$), and World Vision ($b = .125$; $t = 2.575$; $R^2 = .016$). The effect of distinctiveness on brand choice intention was not significant for Red Cross ($b = .067$; $t = 1.227$; $R^2 = .004$). Our findings confirm that integrating both prominence and distinctiveness into brand salience better explain variance in brand choice intention than that of either prominence or distinctiveness.

Discussion and Implications

Drawing upon an extensive literature review, industry expert, and donor in-depth interviews, we conceptualized and operationalized brand salience and its dimensions in the context of monetary donation to international aid-related charities by new donors. Brand salience reflects the prominence and distinctiveness of a specific brand being thought of in relation to other brands in a certain buying situation. Accordingly, we conceptualized and demonstrated that brand salience is composed of two dimensions namely prominence and distinctiveness. All psychometric properties were satisfactory across samples and studies. Most importantly, brand salience has behavioral impact in that it positively influences brand choice intention. This finding is an early indication of the importance of this measure as a means by which donors choose between charity brands for donation.

Table 4. Results of Measurement and Structural Model for All Charity Brands.

Comparison of weights and loadings for formative indicators across charity brands						
Indicator	Charity brand	Turnover (2010) \$'000's	Weight	t-value	Loading	t-value
Prominence	UNICEF	23	0.85	13.43**	0.90	17.33**
	Oxfam	82	0.92	17.58**	0.97	37.64**
	World Vision	347	0.97	24.84**	0.99	56.95**
	Red Cross	798	1.00	46.68**	1.00	101.42**
Distinctiveness	UNICEF	23	0.45	4.38**	0.54	5.39**
	Oxfam	82	0.24	2.32**	0.46	4.44**
	World Vision	347	0.12	1.05	0.31	2.52*
	Red Cross	798	-0.03	0.26	0.15	1.22
Significance of paths and variance explained—all charity brands						
Charity brand	N	Path significance			R ²	
		Brand salience to brand choice intention			Brand choice intention	
		Beta	t			
Red Cross	300	.475	9.832**		.225	
World Vision	300	.444	9.733**		.197	
Oxfam	300	.489	11.061**		.239	
UNICEF	300	.462	10.262**		.214	

UNICEF: United Nations Children's Fund.

*Significant at .05 level. **Significant at .01 level.

The methods used to develop measures of brand salience, facilitate straightforward replication in contexts other than charitable giving. Our findings raise a number of conceptual, measurement, and managerial implications.

Conceptual implications

Our study shows that the brand salience construct is grounded in existing theory from the commercial sector but applied to the charity sector for the first time. Making salient the role of context in conceptualizing brand salience reflects the contextual nature of the construct calls for shaping and modification to fit the situation, by definition. The explicit inclusion of “distinctiveness” as a formative indicator in addition to “prominence,” which traditionally stands alone as a single item measure of the construct (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2004), reflects such modification, taking cognizance of the opinions of sector experts and choice experiences of new donors. Although single-item measures are often recommended as the best approach where a construct is narrowly defined (e.g., Bergkvist & Rossiter, 2007; Sackett & Larson, 1990), brand salience was not considered to be unidimensional, due to a substantive distinction evident between being thought of and being noticed.

Methodological and measurement implications

Variation is observed in the significance of the weights and loadings of the formative indicators of the brand salience measurement model across brands (Table 4). Prominence is clearly the dominant indicator, as weights and loadings are significant across all brands and larger than those for distinctiveness in all cases. However, upon examination of the brands ranked according to turnover, the contribution of prominence is evidently larger for the bigger brands and smaller for the smaller brands.¹ In contrast, the contribution

of distinctiveness is significant for the smaller brands but reduces in significance for the bigger brands. This could be attributed to a crowding out effect in memory. New donors have more developed networks of associations in relation to bigger brands that cause these brands to readily be thought of in relation to attribute cues, without the need for distinctive brand assets. In contrast, new donors have a smaller network of associations in memory in relation to the smaller brands, causing core distinctive assets to be more important in the brand being thought of or noticed. The results call into question the relevance of the indicator in providing content to the formative brand salience index. However, there is clear support for its retention. First, the significant contribution of distinctiveness to the measure of brand salience for smaller brands contributes to the magnitude of the influence of the construct in such cases, where it might otherwise be underreported. Retention of an indicator in cases where it has no significant effect should have almost no effect on parameter estimates, thereby demonstrating no real benefit by its removal (Hair et al., 2011). Second, as the conceptualization of brand salience provides strong support for the inclusion of distinctiveness as an indicator by means of content and face validity, it should be retained in the formative measurement model (Hair et al., 2011). It is up to the researcher to explain any empirical outcomes that follow.

Managerial implications

The findings from our research have several implications for brand managers. First, our findings enable brand managers to address an important changeling task: to ensure that customers can identify the brand and associate it with specific attributes. Our research provides guidelines regarding the potential of each brand salience dimension (i.e., prominence and distinctiveness) for differentiating among brands. Indeed, prominence and distinctiveness contribute to the explanation of observed variance in brand choice intention, and both

dimensions should not be neglected. Our findings can assist brand managers in demonstrating how prominence and distinctiveness can be targeted through prominence-related attributes and a representative range of logos, colors, and specific activities to influence customers' brand choice.

Second, the described methodology provides a means whereby researchers and managers can develop contextual measures for brand salience so that the construct may be included within contextual models and tested for influence on brand or charity choice. We found that brand salience has a profound effect on related consumer behavior. By partitioning brand salience, managers can determine the individual influence of prominence and distinctiveness on brand salience. For small brands, for example, consistent and regular usage of distinctive assets is crucial in order for potential donors to correctly associate stimuli or communications with the correct charity brand, thereby building the network of associations in memory. Irrespective of brand size, however, cognizance of the evident relationship between brand salience and brand choice intention should spur managers to consider ways in which they can build and refresh links in memory between the brand and its associations, to increase relative prominence.

Limitations and future research

As with any research project, the choices made, and constraints placed upon this study imply limitation in how results should be interpreted. Cognizance of these limitations is important when considering the results presented and their implications. Given the conceptualization of brand salience as a formative measurement model, analysis via PLS required the concept to be included within a larger model with consequences. Hence, the construct was tested in relation to an eventual outcome variable of charity brand choice intention, as opposed to another donor behavior outcome. The contextual nature of the brand salience construct also required the selection of a specific donation situation in which to base the study, with the aftermath of a natural disaster chosen over other potential situations and the prompted charity brands specifically related to the provision of disaster relief services. Brands were prompted, but this is not expected to impact on validity (as per Romaniuk et al., 2004). Although we expended a considerable amount of time and effort on ensuring the survey scenario stimulus was realistic and facilitated transportation (Green, 2004; Green & Brock, 2000), it is still only an approximation of a real event and the potential for associated error remains. Consequently, scale development and testing for the brand salience constructs occurs within this context and would need to be adapted to fit other contexts, using the proposed methodology. The sample frame may also warrant care with regard to generalizability of the findings. Although the respondent sample of new donors was drawn to approximate the demographic profile of Australian givers to charity, the potential for a cohort effect exists, as they were all sourced online. The data utilized are cross-sectional, as opposed to longitudinal. Therefore, certain brands may demonstrate relatively higher or lower levels of brand salience, depending on whether there has been a recent communications campaign by a certain charity, for example. Another limitation is the use of intention to donate as a dependent variable given the possibility of social desirability bias. Future research may empirically examine the effect of brand salience on actual behavior in this context.

Furthermore, while the focus on new donors in our study is useful to mitigate the effects of past behavior toward the brand, it may limit the applicability of our model to another context. Future research may focus on the important role of memorable brand experience in a real-life context when charity companies may approach past donors. This is even more interesting when share of brands (e.g., larger versus smaller) is taken into consideration.

Although we expect the proposed scales and methodology of scale development to be generalizable, the proposed scales and methodology of scale development should be tested in other giving and buying situations in both charity and commercial contexts to determine whether this assertion holds. The charity donation empirical setting and a limited context within that could limit the generalizability of our findings. Future research should examine how the results from donating to disaster relief in the charity sector might apply to more mainstream for-profit choice situations like buying toothpaste or a cell phone. In addition, there may be other factors responsible for the non-significance of the distinctiveness indicator in certain circumstances, while being significant in others. The existence or lack of heterogeneous data structures should be examined prior to further discussion of indicator elimination. This can be done by partitioning the data based on existing dimensions (Rigdon et al., 2010), such as demographic variables, or by using the finite mixture PLS method (Ringle et al., 2010). Brand salience should be included in a more comprehensive model of brand choice or donor behavior, to investigate the relationships between latent variables. For example, Vieceli and Shaw's (2010) call for a model which incorporates both brand salience and brand attitudes to unlock the question how does brand salience work. In this regard, possible mediators would be brand authenticity and brand personality through which brand salience works. Given the argument of memory heuristics, category involvement would moderate the effect of brand salience. Our development of measures for the brand salience construct is a first step in answering this call.

Author's Note

Lu Lu is now affiliated with The University of Adelaide, Australia.

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Note

1. Table 4 shows turnovers of the studied brands according to which Red Cross is the largest brand followed by World Vision, Oxfam, and UNICEF.

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Appendix I

Survey stimulus scenario

Disaster unfolding in Bali

It has now been two days since a Tsunami slammed into the coast of Bali and southern Java in Indonesia. The tsunami was similar in size to that which hit the northern part of the country in 2004, and more powerful than the Tsunami that hit Japan earlier this year.



With the death toll rising and many people still missing, the southern coastline is unrecognisable. The Tsunami has flattened holiday resorts and whole neighbourhoods. Electricity and communication lines have been cut, causing residents to wander the waterlogged streets in search of food and missing family members. For many, the only possessions they have left are the clothes they are wearing.

The town of Denpasar, particularly the area around Kuta Beach, has been destroyed. Locals and tourists, including a number of Australians, were given only 10 minutes to escape the wall of water after the Tsunami warning system failed. For many, this was not enough time to get to higher ground.



Almost no building survived the Tsunami without extensive damage. Wayan Pedjeng, a carpenter, stands on the street where he used to sell wooden furniture. His shop is gone, but of greatest concern to him is his son, who he has not heard from since the wave hit.

For those lucky enough to escape the Tsunami, very little food or clean drinking water is available. Medical attention is needed for the injured, while thousands of frightened children need to be reunited with their parents. Shelters must be built to house the homeless and more rescue teams are needed to search for survivors.

Apart from the immediate need, Bali will require continued support. It is going to take a long time to rebuild the homes and lives of the many people so tragically affected by this disaster. However, if Bali is to return to the happy, thriving island it once was, help from the rest of the world is vital.

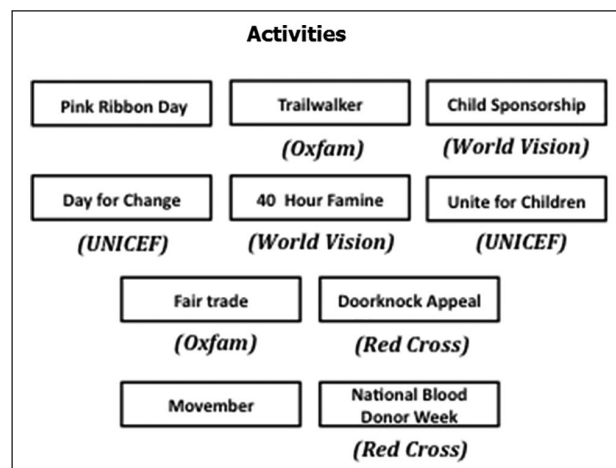
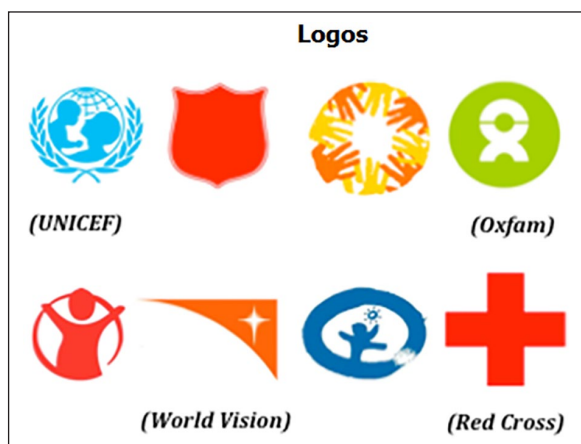
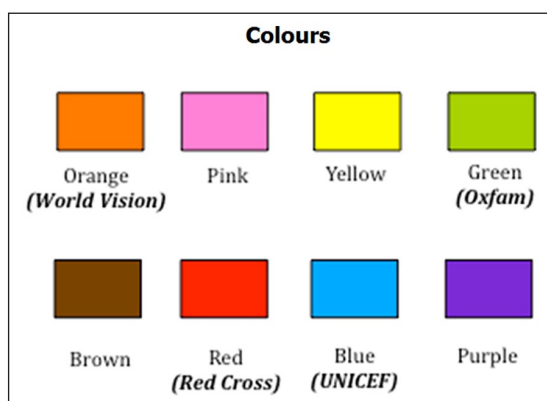
Appendix 2

Brand salience—prominence-related attributes

1. When help is needed immediately
2. When children are in danger
3. When people have lost everything
4. When long-term assistance is needed
5. When people need to feel safe
6. When those affected are very poor
7. When basic services need to be restored (water, electricity, shelter)
8. When people have no food
9. When a large portion of the community is affected
10. When those affected are in remote areas

Appendix 3

Brand salience—distinctiveness



Appendix 4

Brand choice intention

If you were to **donate money** to assist those affected by the disaster, **how much money** would you give? Type an amount (in Australian Dollars) into the block below.

Value of donation (\$)

Given the disaster that you have just read about, what **charities** can you think of that would be likely to **provide assistance to the people affected by the disaster**? Type in the name(s) of at least one, and up to four charities in the order that you think of them. Type the first one in the first block; second one in the second and so on.

Charities providing assistance to people affected by disaster

First charity thought of

Second charity

Third charity

Fourth charity

3.1.3 Third charity

3.1.4 Fourth charity

Note: At least one charity name must be typed in for a respondent to proceed.